

IMMIGRATION AND THE PSYCHODYNAMICS OF CLASS

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Numerous psychoanalytic contributors have theorized about the substantive role played by cultural factors in organizing individual identity. In addition to individual and family dynamics, issues related to class, race, religion, and other cultural themes also exert a vital presence in the treatment setting. These social forces define experience in profound ways from which it is impossible that form an inextricable part of an individual's psychology. Societal values, norms, and forces are carried and represented, forming an ever-present backdrop to our psychological lives. They thus become, perforce, part of the treatment process whether or not the therapist or analyst is aware of their presence. In prior work I have explored the topic of the immigrant's construction of self as it relates to social class (Ainslie, 2009). I argue that one of the variables that shape an immigrant's psychology is his or her social class position in his or her country of origin. In the present contribution, I seek to extend this exploration of the topic of social class and the psychology of immigration through three vignettes that capture aspects of how social class becomes represented in the experience and therapeutic treatment of immigrants.

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For more than two decades now, psychoanalytic theorists have increasingly engaged the topics of culture, society, and class; however, psychoanalysts still do not delve into this terrain comfortably. With a few notable exceptions, theoretical formulation or clinical exploration of these topics remains on the margins. The reasons are as varied as they are complex. Notwithstanding works such as *Totem and Taboo*, *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego*, or *Civilization and its Discontents*, Freud's legacy lies more with the constructs that bequeathed psychoanalysis as a clinical project rather than the constructs that theorized the origins of culture, human social processes, and how we function at a collective level, not to mention the impact of society upon the individual and upon the psyche of the group.

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Arguably, one of the sources of this narrowed scope is the extent to which psychoanalysis, as a discipline, has been influenced and affected by a group immigration experience, although this influence is not fully acknowledged. Jacoby (1983) has pointed out that the psychoanalytic Diaspora, just before and during the Second World War, created its own social and intellectual dynamics within the world of psychoanalysis: many psychoanalysts who were active in the cultural, political, and artistic spheres in their countries of origin ceased to be public intellectuals post migration and turned their energies (and hence, what they chose to theorize about) inward. Though the two never enjoyed equal footing, the personal came to be privileged over the social to an unprecedented extent. Jacoby argues that the immigration experience proved to be traumatic and psychically taxing, such that it shaped the universe of postwar psychoanalytic theory and practice. A symptom of that psychological stress, he posits, was a truncating of the psychoanalytic vision and, perhaps, of psychoanalytic identity itself insofar as all too often psychoanalysts came to feel that they were only truly analysts when sitting behind the couch listening to their patients. In fact, with the exception of the obligatory “applied” course, most psychoanalytic institutes leave little space in their curriculums for psychoanalytic exploration of the psychology of culture, society, and related topics. It would appear, then, that the impact of the psychoanalytic Diaspora on the psychology of the newly emigrated analysts itself reflects, or is an illustrative instance of, the intimate and powerful relationship between sociocultural experience and individual psychology, a relationship that affects every dimension of an immigrant’s life.

The Psychology of Immigration

A growing body of work has helped us to understand the psychological experience of immigration from a psychoanalytically informed perspective. One of the earliest and most important contributions to this literature is Volkan’s (1981) article on linking objects and linking phenomena, in which he discusses pathological mourning as a characteristic feature of immigrant psychology. This complicated mourning process can interfere with the transformation of mental representations of family, land, and identity as distance dilutes or loosens the tethers that connect immigrants to “home” and as they find themselves immersed in new circumstances. Volkan argues that these dynamics transform immigrants into “perennial mourners” (p. 542). Related themes are taken up in the classic psychoanalytic treatment of immigration by Grinberg and Grinberg (1989) who explore the immigrant’s experience of loss as well as the unique stresses that come from having to exist and function in a world where one’s mother tongue is no longer the operative language. They argue that this circumstance creates enormous stresses on identity.

Akhtar (1991, 1994) has discussed the experience of the immigrant as one shrouded with “someday” and “if only” reveries about the homeland that one has left behind. These are fantasies about what one’s life might have been had one not migrated. In part, such fantasies serve defensive and compensatory functions in the face of the psychological challenges that accompany the attempt to engage a new culture and to redefine self-representations in light of these challenges. Similarly, Tummala-Narra (2009) examines the construct of “home” in the context of the immigrant’s real and imagined return home. Along related lines, elsewhere (Ainslie, 1998) I have explored the character of “cultural mourning” as immigrants struggle to adjust to the realities of being away from home by creating or transforming public spaces so that they serve a variety of psychically important functions. For example, these settings serve as transitional spaces that are simultaneously “here” and “there,” “present” and “past,” and within which immigrants psychically and

materially engage current challenges. These spaces also serve emotionally reparative functions.

Class Identities, Immigration, and Clinical Work

Numerous psychoanalytic contributors have theorized about the substantive, structuring role played by cultural factors in organizing individual identity. Winnicott (1967), for example, argues that culture is part of the fundamental matrix of infant and mothering-object experiences and inseparable from these. Building on these ideas, Volkan (1997) has mapped out the intimate relationship between individual and collective identity as they are given shape by social and cultural forces, including ethnicity, religion, and other important elements around which identity becomes constructed.

Once we are alerted to them, such social-cultural factors have obvious clinical implications, as numerous theorists point out. Altman (2000), for example, has examined the treatment implications when analyst and patient are from different cultural backgrounds. In one case, Altman, who is Jewish, explores the transference countertransference issues raised in his treatment of an African-American patient. Altman makes the point that societal stereotypes and other preconceptions were alive and active within the treatment situation for both he and his patient by virtue of the fact that both were shaped by these societal forces, even if in different ways. In other words, Altman is arguing for the notion that in addition to individual and family dynamics, issues related to class, race, religion, and other cultural themes also exert a vital presence in the treatment setting. These social forces define experience in profound ways from which it is impossible for an individual to disconnect himself. They become, perforce, part of the treatment process whether or not the therapist is aware of their presence. Layton (2002) theorizes that these social and cultural positions form part of what she calls the normative unconscious, and they do so in powerful, defining ways. Castoriadis (1987) has argued a related thesis in describing what he terms the Social Imaginary, by which he intends to capture the idea that societal values, norms, and forces are carried and represented, forming an ever-present backdrop to our psychological lives.

In prior work I have explored the topic of the immigrant's construction of self as it relates to social class (Ainslie, 2009). I argue that one of the variables that shape an immigrant's psychology is his or her social class position in his or her country of origin.

In the present contribution, I seek to extend this exploration of the topic of social class and the psychology of immigration through three vignettes that capture aspects of how social class becomes represented in the experience and therapeutic treatment of immigrants.

Clinical Note 1: Traveling With One's Social Class¹

Immigrants travel with their social contexts; they are part of an internalized world that substantively structures their psychological experience of themselves and others, including the world to which they have come. Class identities are part of the psychological matrix out of which immigrants attempt to make sense of themselves and the world to which they have come. These class identities are deeply encoded, and significant dimensions of them are unconscious and/or simply accepted as the way the world "is." And, they operate in powerful ways. Take, for example, the following vignette:

¹ This material is derived from personal communications.

A woman who grew up in a lower working class family in Texas married a Mexican businessman and moved to Mexico City, where she eventually entered psychoanalysis with a prominent Mexican psychoanalyst. She was, in other words, an immigrant. The woman was white, and her social milieu in Mexico included many American expatriates, mostly businessmen and diplomats, as well as upper-class Mexicans who often were “white” in terms of skin color. Although she was well liked within this new social milieu, her working class roots chronically made her feel vulnerable, given that most of her compatriots in Mexico had come from middle- or upper-class backgrounds in the United States and most were college-educated (her own education had not gone beyond high school). Such was the extent of her class anxiety that she sought voice lessons in order to erase her pronounced Texas accent, believing that it betrayed her class origins, origins that included traumatic class-based elements (she had been raised by a single parent after her father abandoned the family, and, as a consequence, at times the family had lived in abject poverty). While many aspects of her family relationships and upbringing were explored in the course of her analysis, complex feelings related to her social class, including the feelings that fueled her decision to take voice lessons, were never discussed, even though, as she would later recount, these were a constant source of vulnerability and concern. As a result, while other dimensions of her emotional life were strengthened in the course of her analysis, the class-based anxieties remained raw and unresolved. She remained hyper aware of class differences, and her transformed self-representation from lower working class to being a member of the upper class was a source of narcissistic gratification to which she clung defensively, with attendant devaluation of those “below” her station. The latter were unconscious carriers of loathed and extruded self-representations, embodiments of a deeply feared position of need, marginalization, and helplessness from her childhood. For this individual, then, issues of social class were activated or accentuated as part of the immigration experience.

Clinical Note 2: Transgenerational Transmission of Class Anxieties

Volkan (1997) describes how it is that collective experiences that are psychologically powerful and defining may become handed down from generation to generation, often in complex and unconscious ways. Moments of collective triumph or defeat, for example, may be internalized and become part of collective identity in the form of Chosen Traumas and Chosen Glories. These collective experiences find individual expression and are internalized as part of individual identity as well.

Immigration experiences are often part of a group experience given that individual decisions to migrate are frequently part of a larger collective process. In the United States, for example, this is reflected in the fact that there have been historical intervals when waves of migration were defined by specific group membership, such as when Irish, Italians, Jews, or Mexicans formed the predominant immigration groups. For people who migrate as part of these collective movements, the psychological dimensions of these migration experiences are simultaneously represented individually and collectively. In this second clinical note, a patient appeared to struggle with a transgenerationally transmitted conflict related to her grandparents’ immigrant experience.

The patient was in her late 20s and a graduate student at the time she entered treatment. The daughter of successful attorneys, she came from an upper-middle class Jewish family in the northeast. All four of her grandparents had immigrated to the United States from Poland, and all had spent their lives in working class jobs and living in working class environments. Her maternal grandparents, with whom she shared a special bond, were also

highly political and active in labor unions and leftist causes. There was a tight weave between her grandparents' immigrant status, their economic circumstances in the United States, and their political views. They also saw themselves as outsiders, with outsider political sensibilities and foreign accents and foreign customs that indelibly marked them as immigrants. As a child, my patient was keenly aware of her grandparents' immigrant backgrounds, although the specific circumstances of their migration were never discussed nor was there nostalgic talk about the Old Country and the people or the places left behind. She would later surmise that this might have been attributable to the traumatic circumstances under which they had lived in prewar Eastern Europe before migrating and because of the deep sense of loss and dislocation that they felt in relation to this experience. This was, in other words, an unspoken and unacknowledged trauma that encircled their lives.

As is often true for immigrant families, the patient's grandparents struggled and sacrificed so that their children could have a better life and, indeed, her parents attended college, then law school, and became successful professionals. They, in turn, sent their own children to private schools and then to elite universities. However, although my patient was raised in a social milieu that included nannies and upper-middle class privilege, as a child she also spent a great deal of time with her maternal grandparents, where she was immersed in the political viewpoints and the acknowledged and unacknowledged aspects of their immigrant status. While the Old Country was never discussed, its existence was continuously invoked and betrayed by the thickly accented speech that characterized every word they spoke, as well as by the foods they ate, the books and magazines they read (many of which were in the grandparents' native language), and even by the decorative aesthetics that they chose for their apartment.

The patient entered treatment because she was experiencing intense anxiety in relation to her professional training. She felt torn between pursuing a specialization that would be financially lucrative and one that she would find "more socially meaningful and relevant." She was quite anxious about beginning twice-a-week treatment and had taken the step to seek a referral only after her anxiety had become debilitating. She initially sought out medication, and her anxiety about therapy was made even more acute when her psychiatrist told her that coming more than once a week "was passé." Her biggest concern, she said in her initial appointments, centered on a fear and self-consciousness that she was just "a cliché": "It feels like I'm just another Upper East Side kid of successful professionals who manages the minor stresses of her basically pampered life by resorting to an analyst." "Why can't I just suck it up like everyone else does?" she asked. In other words, her anxiety about entering therapy was voiced in terms of her class position, a position that afforded her, if guiltily, the opportunity to be in more intensive treatment.

Her resistance to more in-depth work was framed in terms of class embarrassment, class anxiety, and class shame. Especially during the first year of her treatment, this "only pampered rich people engage in this kind of treatment" defense was often mobilized when she drew closer to painful or difficult material. I would argue that, among other contributions and meanings, these sentiments were given particular shape by the transgenerational transmission of feelings that had been part of her grandparents' immigration experience. Her grandparents' leftist politics, reinforced by an immigrant worldview that made their marginalized, outsider status ever salient, existed as something split off and nonmetabolized within her upwardly mobile nuclear family. Her parents, for example, never discussed politics and pursued social and economic success with the same, if apolitical, fervor with which her grandparents had clung to leftist political causes. One of the multiple meanings represented by her conflict between pursuing a lucrative profes-

sional career or a socially meaningful one was that it embodied two discordant psychological realities (her grandparents' world view and her parents' world view) with which she had grown up.

My patient encountered these two conflicting representations in the transference. She had explored my background on the Internet and discovered that some of my work had a "socially conscious" or "activist" character. At the same time, my office was nicely furnished and I had *The New Yorker* in my waiting room, things that she labeled as upper-class. She wondered, too, "how I reconciled" working on these topics while at the same time earning independent practice fees. In other words, she wondered how I managed the very contradictions with which she was struggling in her own life, the same contradictions that had her so hobbled and stuck in terms of her career decisions. These were familial conflicts, as well, and it had been left for my patient, as a transmitted psychological task (Volkan, 1997), to reconcile these divergent strands of psychic experience that permeated life within her family. Her treatment helped her accomplish this, partly via an exploration of the transference.

Clinical Note 3: Immigration as Narcissistic Wounding

Grinberg and Grinberg (1989), among others, have noted that the experience of immigration often entails both obvious and subtle narcissistic wounds. For example, the effort required to communicate even basic needs in a language other than one's mother tongue is taxing and regressive. There is often a sense of being diminished or of not being fully oneself and not being "seen" by others as a whole person who has competence and skills. This is part of the "culture shock" described by Garza-Guerrero (1974) in which the process of engaging a new culture does not provide corroborative environmental feedback for one's identity. "Exposed to his new culture, the newcomer's interactions with it fails . . . to provide the basic elements upon which his own identity is solidly maintained" (p. 418). In addition, for many immigrants, the mere fact of having to leave one's native land raises narcissistic vulnerabilities because there is frequently a thread of defeat and failure in it, suggesting that the immigrant was unable to "make it" at home.

Such feelings may be further accentuated by how those who have been left behind (family, friends, and the broader community) perceive the decision to migrate. Such attitudes are often complex and may include quite a broad range of feelings, including idealizing views of the immigrant who is seen as an adventurer and hero, but also devaluating views of the emigrant who is viewed as someone who has left home in pursuit of easy money, or as someone who could not "make it" at home and who has abandoned his or her culture and values for economic gain (Ainslie & Dominquez, in press). For a variety of reasons, then, the experience of immigration may represent a psychic strain that has significant narcissistic components. The following vignette illustrates this predicament in a woman whose class status was lowered following migration:

This patient entered treatment when she was in her late twenties because she was suffering from significant depression. She had graduated from university and was working successfully in a business setting. She and her mother had immigrated to the United States from Latin America when she was an early adolescent. For reasons having to do with problems in their marriage, my patient's father did not migrate with them but rather remained in their country of origin. Her parents remained legally married but, in fact, lived as divorced people who had no contact with one another.

Unlike the upper-class status they had enjoyed in their country of origin, in this country mother and daughter struggled to make ends meet throughout most of my

patient's adolescent years. Thus, as distinct from the more usual immigrant experience in which economic standing is enhanced for immigrants by the sacrifices entailed in leaving their home countries, in this instance coming to the United States actually represented a diminution of economic and social status.²

My patient's relationship with her mother might be characterized as symbiotic. Her mother intruded into every facet of her life and had a strong need to control her. In addition, the mother used her daughter as a confidant and as a repository for anger toward her estranged husband, as well as for her depression and isolation. My patient's mother also permeated their interactions with her anxieties about work and her concerns about family back home and relationships with people in her present life. My patient's mother was extremely isolated in the United States and clung to her daughter mightily as they had no other relatives living in this country. Because of her own narcissistic character traits, which were compounded by the specific circumstances of her immigration experience, my patient's mother was obsessed with issues of social class, constantly reminding her daughter that they had come from people of means in their country of origin where they had enjoyed life in an upper-class enclave tended by servants and where they had a measure of influence and social standing.

For her mother, being in the United States was an ever-present source of narcissistic injury: She felt humiliated by the fact that she had to work at a middle-class job to make enough money to live a modest middle-class life that she felt was below her. My patient's mother chronically feared devaluation by others and worried that Americans would take her accent to mean that she was, as she put it, "like the typical Latin-American immigrant," by which she meant people who were less educated and came from poverty. *Those* people, she was prone to say with considerable derision, "lack culture"; that is, she viewed them as not sufficiently cosmopolitan and sophisticated. One of the manifestations of this narcissistic wounding was that her mother's anxieties translated into an ever-present and running commentary about social class and position, including a hyper-alertness to class markers such as the makes of cars, fashion designers, restaurants, neighborhoods, and the like.

Rather than metabolizing her mother's narcissistic wounds or disidentifying from her mother's neurotically based class anxieties, my patient seemed to embody and carry a more raw, primitive version of them. For example, when she was in contact with Latin Americans of a lower social class than her own she felt a great deal of anger and experienced sadistic urges that sometimes unsettled her but which more often were ego-syntonic. Even as she felt anger and rage toward her mother's symbiotic engulfment, she identified with her mother's class anxieties and associated hostilities and often took them a step further by expressing outward contempt toward Latin American immigrants of less fortunate backgrounds. For example, she supported and endorsed anti-immigrant campaigns, including those that had an overtly racist cast, such as the right-wing Minutemen. In one instance, during one session after a highly publicized Immigration and Customs Enforcement raid on a factory that had resulted in the detention and pending deportation of undocumented workers, many of whom had children who would thus be separated from their parents, she said she felt no empathy for the children's plight.

² In fact, in the context of the global economy where recessions are generalized, individuals who emigrate to developed countries as members of professional classes who cannot find employment in their native countries increasingly find themselves occupying positions that are lower in social status than they once enjoyed in their countries of origin.

Ignoring the fact that these parents were working and not on welfare, she summarized her rage toward them as follows: "I'm paying for them to raise those loser children, loser families, that do not do anything."

The intensity of her rage and devaluation of fellow immigrants who came from a lower social class in her own country had multiple origins and served multiple functions. The class prejudices that are characteristic of her country of origin had traveled with her, as part of her psychic organization, becoming more accentuated in this country. The targets of her hostility were typically fellow countrymen with whom conceivably she might have felt a degree of solidarity and empathy given their shared language and culture. However, such prejudices are powerful psychic organizers. Back home, such class prejudices and distinctions were "held," to some extent, by the social structures within which she and her family lived. Those structures made the otherness of those of less fortunate circumstances feel less threatening because they were contained and organized by the norms and conventions of that society. However, given that she and her mother had actually lost social and economic status, her migration experience in effect reduced the social distance between her and these devalued compatriots, creating regressive anxieties and greater intrapsychic tensions. This is a variant of the dynamics described by Freud under the concept of "narcissism of minor differences" (see Volkan, 1988), where lessened distinctions and more permeable boundaries create heightened antagonisms.

However, the intensity of this patient's rage was fueled by more personal and idiosyncratic psychodynamics that became linked to these social prejudices and that used them as a channel for the expression of personal conflicts. For example, in the course of her treatment she was surprised to discover the extent to which she felt rage toward her mother, yet she felt very anxious and guilty when she let herself delve into these feelings. Her mother's need to control my patient and to intrude into her inner life was infuriating, yet she also acutely felt her mother's isolation, vulnerability, and neediness. She felt sorry for her mother, especially in the context of her mother's loneliness. Such feelings made her feel very protective of her mother, and it was difficult for her to confront her mother about their relationship or about her mother's failure to establish her own life in her adopted country. In this sense, this patient's animosity toward her compatriots of lesser status also served as a displacement for her conflicts with her mother. They were isolated, vulnerable, and needy, the very feelings that she identified with her mother's experience, and, to some extent, her own experience as well. Thus, as with the case described in the first vignette, these fellow immigrants could also conveniently serve as receptacles for unwanted, devalued parts of herself. However, for the patient described in Case Note 1, class anxieties were mobilized in the context of upward social movement, whereas in this case they were mobilized by a relative lowering of social status.

Conclusion

Psychoanalytic theory has shed a rich light on various dimensions of the immigration experience. In particular, this literature has helped us understand the psychodynamics of loss and mourning, as well as the unique stresses that are created by finding oneself in a foreign land, unable to speak the language, where even basic, taken-for-granted actions may be taxing and require significant expenditures of effort and readily create significant narcissistic wounding. In addition, there are reparative efforts that are mobilized in the context of immigrating to a new country, such as reveries and the creation of transitional spaces. Immigrants use these to help absorb the stress of what they are enduring.

Class identities are more important and more charged than typically thought. In the present contribution I have sought to further explore the ways in which immigrants carry class identities, how these form an important part of who they are, and how they play an important role in how they experience and manage the psychological challenges that they face in a new country. Most often, immigration experiences alter one's class position. Whether the immigrant's social status is elevated, as in Case Note 1, or, as in Case Note 3, lowered by immigrating. Changes in class position, even when these are in a desired direction, may represent threats to identity and mobilize a variety of regressive responses.

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